Disclaimer:

This presentation does not necessarily represent the viewpoints of Arup, TfL or the GLA. All information presented is publicly available either directly or via an FOI request



Why do our high streets look like this?



When our peer cities' look like this:

I.

The ‘public’ in ‘public goods’ is defined very narrowly

In cities like Paris and New York, citywide authorities are able to intervene in the built environment far more easily.

New York, 2009

NEW YORK POST

US NEWS

UGLY 'SQUARE' CHAIRS PILE UP

By James Fanelli

Published Aug. 16, 2009, 6:13 a.m. ET



Paris, 2015

Paris : Anne Hidalgo annonce une piétonisation des quais de la rive droite

Par La rédaction de TF1info

Publié le 18 octobre 2015 à 8h50



London, 2026

THE STANDARD

NEWS | LONDON

London local elections: Tories vow legal challenge to Oxford Street pedestrianisation after Westminster win

Conservatives pledge to mount a legal challenge to Sir Sadiq Khan's controversial scheme after taking back control of council

Council calls for Oxford Street impact assessment



The pedestrianisation of Oxford Street is due to go ahead later this year

PEDESTRIANISATION: LONDON'S OXFORD STREET EXPERIMENT

E. D. TURNER

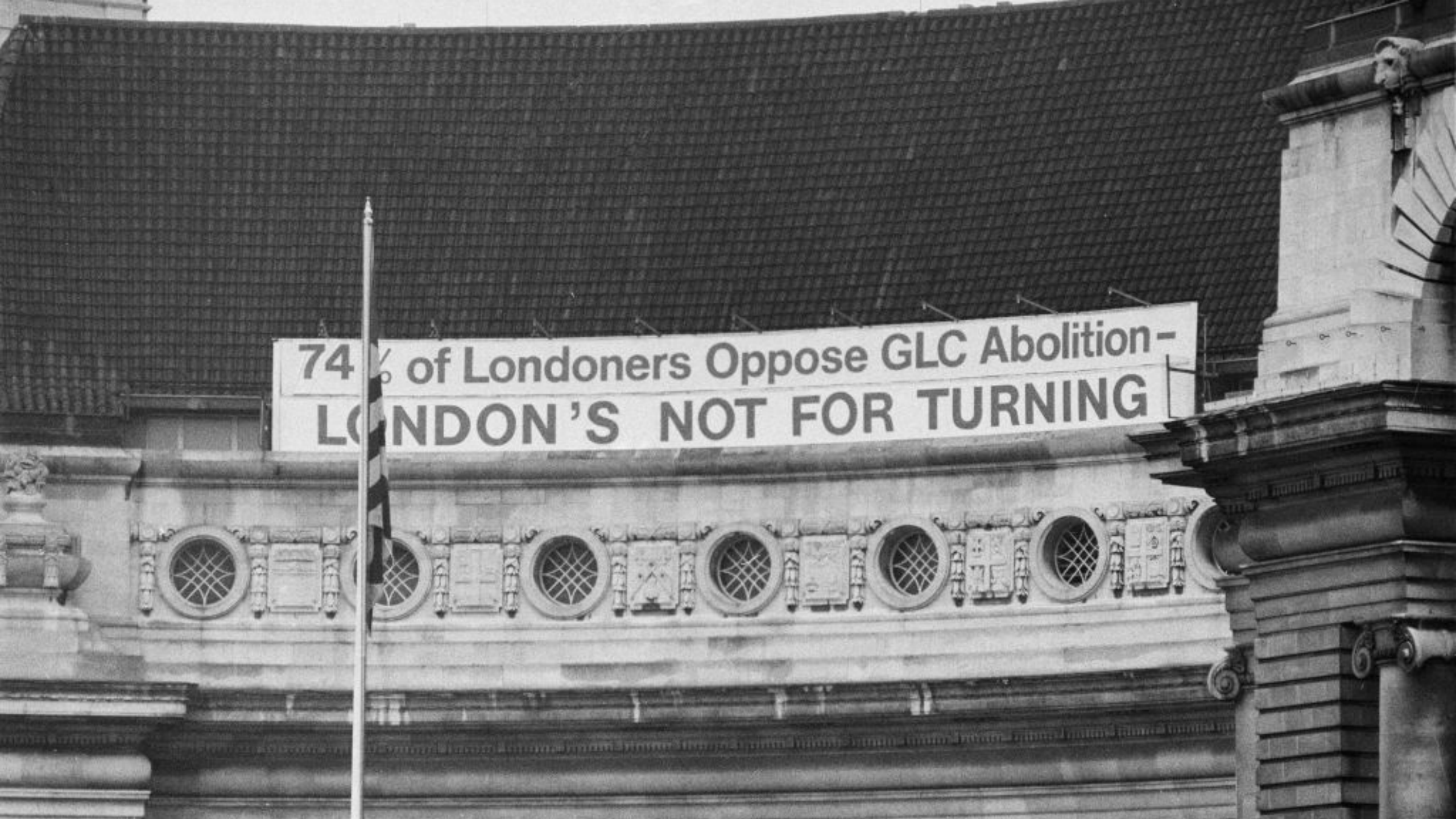
Principal Research Officer, Department of Planning and Transportation, Greater London Council

G. A. GIANNOPOULOS*

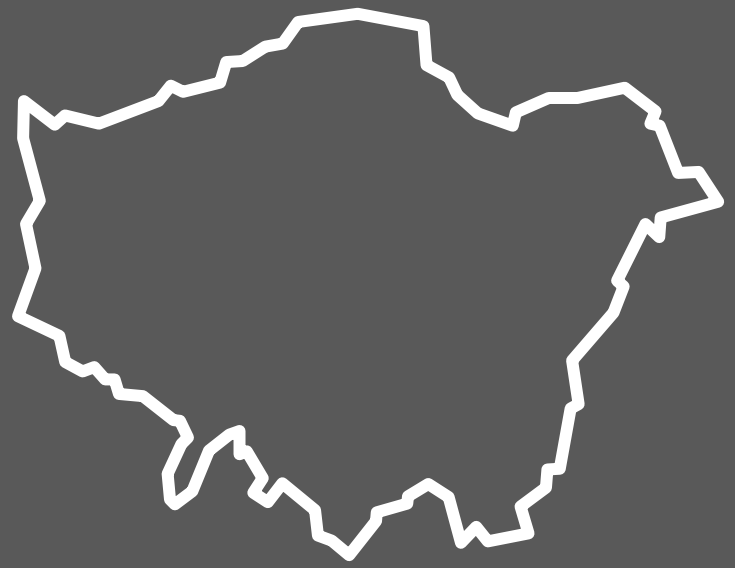
Traffic Engineering Consultant, Athens

Development and Testing of the Alternative Schemes

Following Oxford Street's reputation as the worst in London for the second year running in the GLC blackspot table, a graduate engineer commenced work in March 1971 with the objective of producing schemes for reducing accident numbers (Chamberlain, 1971). Four schemes were considered ranging from minor traffic engineering works (better use of


74% of Londoners Oppose GLC Abolition–
LONDON'S NOT FOR TURNING

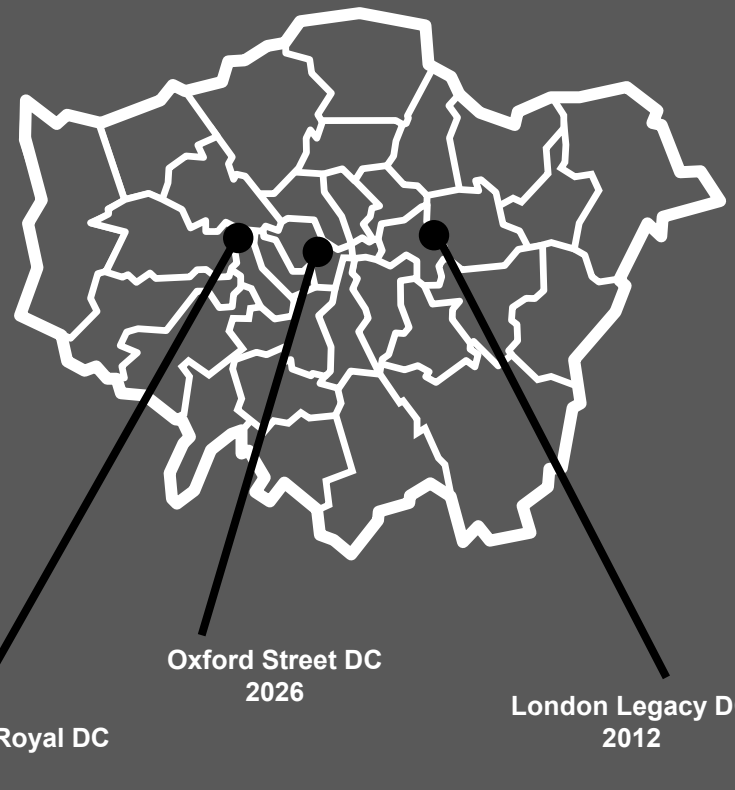
1965-86



1986-2000



2000-



II.

We don’t let the private sector drive the process

It’s hard to argue change is bad for business when business is the one steering it.



LVMH
Galeries Lafayette
Adidas
Citynove



Local property owners
Local restaurants
Advertisers
Theatre groups

III.

Some act, we calculate

The UK has an accountancy-heavy approach to infrastructure delivery which prioritises certain sources of social value over others.

Times Square and Champs-Élysées pedestrianisation began as a pilot:

Biking has increased by 91% on Broadway at 50th Street to an average of 1,411 cyclists a day

The changes on Broadway from Columbus Circle to 48th Street shortened crossing distances and protected pedestrians, reducing crash injuries from an average of 37.7 per year to 23 per year—a decline of 39%.

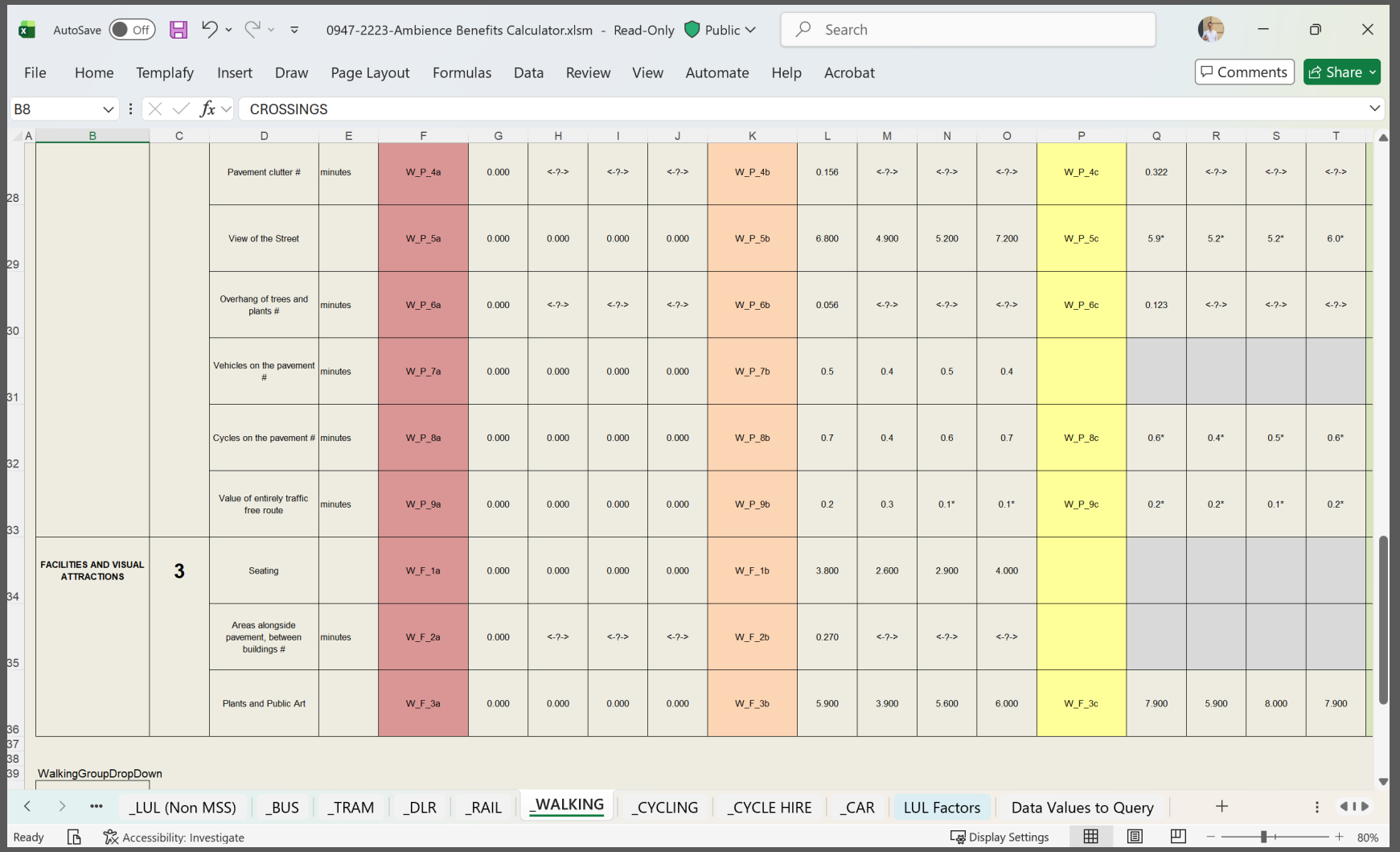
74% of New Yorkers surveyed agreed that Times Square improved dramatically as a result of the project.

Journey times for taxis and buses were improved for the area, even though there was a reduction in road space

Pedestrian injuries in the entire project declined 35%, while 80% fewer pedestrians are walking in the road in Times Square.

Oxford Street pedestrianisation began as a spreadsheet:

(From the TfL Ambiance Benefits Calculator)



AutoSave Off | 0947-2223-Ambience Benefits Calculator.xlsm - Read-Only | Public | Search

File Home Templafy Insert Draw Page Layout Formulas Data Review View Automate Help Acrobat | Comments | Share

B8 | CROSSINGS

28			Pavement clutter #	minutes	W_P_4a	0.000	<-?->	<-?->	<-?->	W_P_4b	0.156	<-?->	<-?->	<-?->	W_P_4c	0.322	<-?->	<-?->	<-?->
29			View of the Street		W_P_5a	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	W_P_5b	6.800	4.900	5.200	7.200	W_P_5c	5.9*	5.2*	5.2*	6.0*
30			Overhang of trees and plants #	minutes	W_P_6a	0.000	<-?->	<-?->	<-?->	W_P_6b	0.056	<-?->	<-?->	<-?->	W_P_6c	0.123	<-?->	<-?->	<-?->
31			Vehicles on the pavement #	minutes	W_P_7a	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	W_P_7b	0.5	0.4	0.5	0.4					
32			Cycles on the pavement #	minutes	W_P_8a	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	W_P_8b	0.7	0.4	0.6	0.7	W_P_8c	0.6*	0.4*	0.5*	0.6*
33			Value of entirely traffic free route	minutes	W_P_9a	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	W_P_9b	0.2	0.3	0.1*	0.1*	W_P_9c	0.2*	0.2*	0.1*	0.2*
34	FACILITIES AND VISUAL ATTRACTIONS	3	Seating		W_F_1a	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	W_F_1b	3.800	2.600	2.900	4.000					
35			Areas alongside pavement, between buildings #	minutes	W_F_2a	0.000	<-?->	<-?->	<-?->	W_F_2b	0.270	<-?->	<-?->	<-?->					
36			Plants and Public Art		W_F_3a	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	W_F_3b	5.900	3.900	5.600	6.000	W_F_3c	7.900	5.900	8.000	7.900
37																				
38																				
39	WalkingGroupDropDown																			

_LUL (Non MSS) _BUS _TRAM _DLR _RAIL _WALKING _CYCLING _CYCLE HIRE _CAR LUL Factors Data Values to Query

Ready | Accessibility: Investigate | Display Settings | 80%

The vast majority of the quantified benefit in the Oxford Street business case is derived from monetising the experience of passing by new trees and plantings.

While the benefits stacked up in this case, other promising ideas may not ‘pencil,’ reducing the chances they will receive funding or planning consent.



Wow…my life is improved (£0.059) just by seeing this tree



x1,000,000s each year = lots of benefit and a very healthy BCR

IV.

We don’t always enforce existing laws

Built environment interventions do little to address tax evasion and other illegal activities.

New York, 2015

N.Y. / REGION

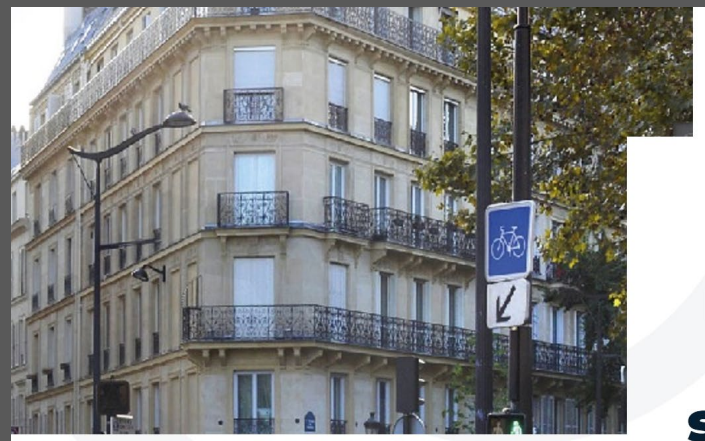
New York Police Dept. Creates Unit to Monitor Times Square Issues



The Police Department is seeking applications from officers to join the Times Square Unit. Their role will be distinct from the counterterrorism duties of officers already there.

Eduardo Munoz Alvarez/Getty Images

Paris, 2017



ACTUALITÉ

Paris va réduire de 40% la surface des publicités

Mise à jour le 29/03/2017

Panneau actuel



Nouveau panneau





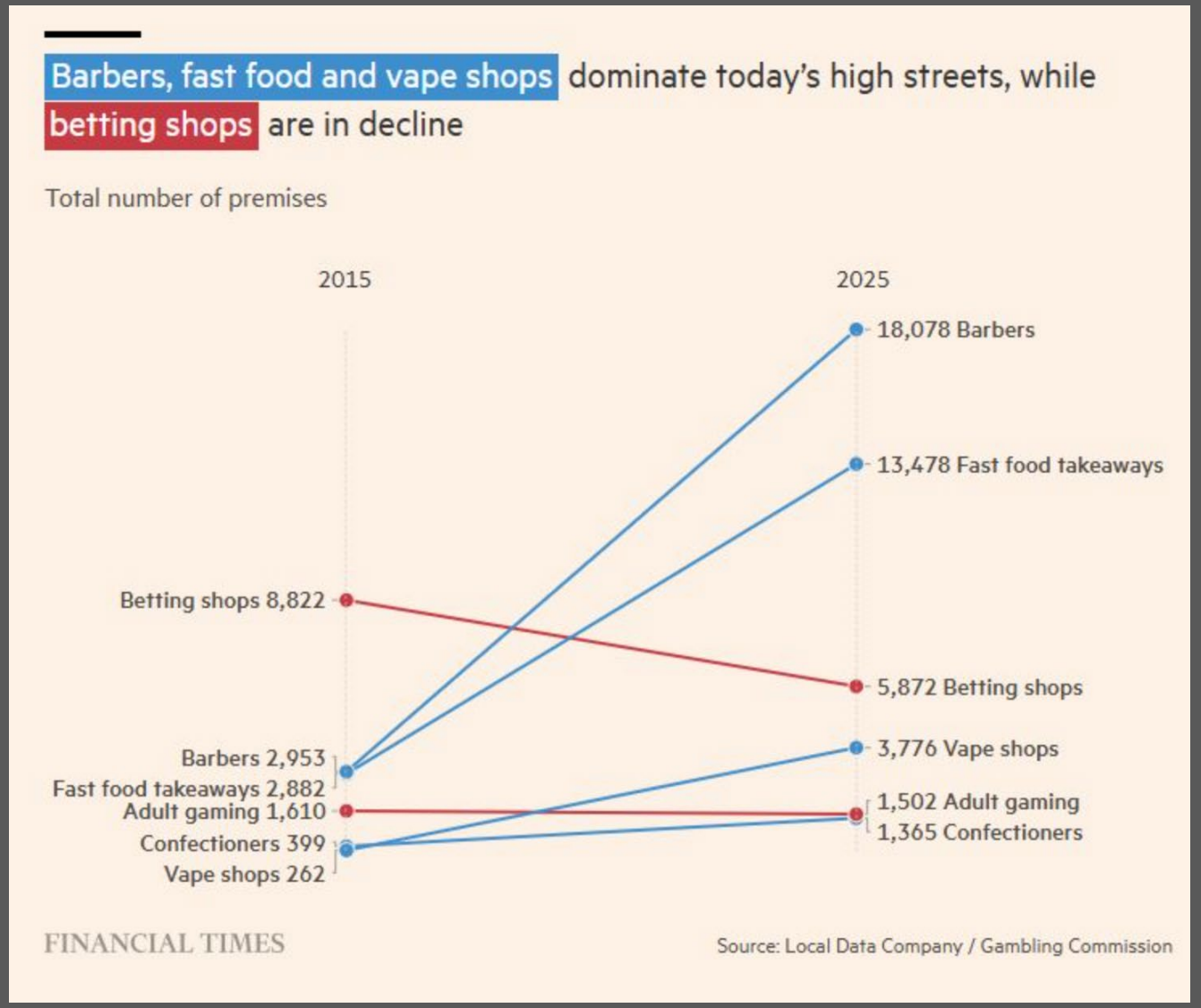
Theft from person, 2021-2025

Raid after candy shop charged £900 for sweets



The Oxford Street candy shop charged tourists £900 for two packets of sweets

Pedestrianisation may not address this…


Barbers, fast food and vape shops dominate today's high streets, while betting shops are in decline
Total number of premises
2015
2025
18,078 Barbers
13,478 Fast food takeaways
Betting shops 8,822
5,872 Betting shops
3,776 Vape shops
Barbers 2,953
Fast food takeaways 2,882
Adult gaming 1,610
1,502 Adult gaming
1,365 Confectioners
Confectioners 399
Vape shops 262
FINANCIAL TIMES
Source: Local Data Company / Gambling Commission

…or this.